

Go back to school

As you've no doubt already gathered from the cover of this month's issue, we're focussing on going back to study – as students of schools or colleges all over India head back after their summer vacations this month. However, this column is not about that.

This month we were all wiped out by sickness for over half the month, and this included even me, all the way on the other side of the Indian Ocean. Sickness may make us geeks not want to work, but it doesn't cause our brains to shut down. Thus, while my wife reminds me that I was pretty much a big baby for the better part of 15 days while I was down with the flu, I was also a big baby in another way – like a baby, I decided to be wowed again, and learn, and brush up on some stuff.

It started with gaming first, obviously – every good tech story should start with gaming, as far as I am concerned. First I went back to relive 2004 as I fired up Half-life 2. I also ended up playing Black Mesa (Half-life 1 on the Source engine), all the while yearning for HL3, like every other Gordon Freeman fan out there. Damn you Valve!

Then, however, I also decided to brush up on my almost nonexistent HTML5 and PHP skills, and although I still suck at them, perhaps I'm just a tad better than before. I'm currently trying to figure out how to write CSS. I'm also going to be rooting my OnePlus 2 and trying custom roms and experimenting. The darn home button on my OP2 died, and now I'm not at all bothered about voiding warranty. Why am I doing this? Does everything need a reason? Can't we just learn and try things for the sake of learning or trying them?

So many of you will go (or have gone) through engineering and end up doing MBAs, or being entrepreneurs, or even working in the family business. It's not like everything we learnt in school or college is needed. Sometimes we just want to learn things for fun.

I've been on a (re)learning science journey for the past year, mostly because of writing the dmystify books, but more because I love science, and life and responsibilities just always got in the way of me being able to do so. As if I needed another reason to love my job at Digit – who doesn't want to be paid to do the stuff they actually would have done for free anyway, right?

The point I'm trying to get at is that this might be the time when all the students go "Back to School", however, if like me, you've also long stopped being a student, perhaps it's time to start being one again. Just because you work, or have kids, or have other priorities right now doesn't mean you can't take some time out to do something just for yourself.

Maybe it's a DIY project you want to start, or you want to learn a new skill, learn to read, write or speak a new language, maybe code in a new language, or read up on a whole new subject... whatever the case, there's just no excuse to not learn something new anymore. Thanks to technology, the internet, smartphones and apps, learning pretty much anything is well within reach now. You can even do online courses, or take up after work part time courses, all depending on how much time you have to spare, how much money you're willing to spend and what kind of learning you want to do.

Maybe you just want to go through all our past Fast Tracks and learn some new skills – we've given them away with last month's June anniversary issue. Whatever choice you make, no matter what skill you choose to learn, no matter how arbitrary, technology is here to help.

As someone who's cooking skills never surpassed the ability to make really bad Maggi (now Patanjali?), I also did some YouTube watching to learn how to make idlis and dosas. They turned out pretty OK, and I'm pretty pleased with myself! I'm taking baby steps with a lot of things, and keeping my mind open (like a child), so that I can also start this school year with all the other "kids", by going back to school. I suggest you do the same. Be shameless, have no fear, openly admit that you don't know something, and then go back to school and learn something new, it's tremendous fun, and very satisfying! 🍴



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor

robert@digit.in

"Just because you work, or have kids, or have other priorities right now doesn't mean you can't take some time out to do something just for yourself"

Liked or hated this column?

Let me know at:

facebook.com/raaabo | [@raaabo](https://twitter.com/raaabo) | robert@digit.in